most Afghans hated their Kafir occupiers. Moreover, Mohan Lal was being watched and Akbar's spies were passing on detailed information about all the Envoy's amateurish attempts at intrigue. There were also damaging rumours circulating among the rebels that Macnaghten was offering money to anyone who would assassinate Akbar and the other hostile chiefs. According to Mirza 'Ata, 'Macnaghten wrote a secret letter to the chiefs, to the effect that whoever would bring Sardar Muhammad Akbar Khan's severed head would be rewarded with a sum of 10,000 Rupees and would be appointed assistant to the Envoy. As soon as the Khans read this, they immediately passed the original on to Akbar Khan who kept it with him.'[117] The story could well be true. Certainly there is evidence from the correspondence of Mohan Lal that a paid assassin called Abdul Aziz sent in an invoice to Mohan Lal for the killing of Abdullah Khan Achakzai, saying he shot him in the back with a poisoned bullet while he was fighting Shelton on 23 November, implying that Mohan Lal had indeed offered a bounty for the killing of rebel leaders.[118] It is extremely unlikely he would have dared to do so without some sort of authorisation from the Envoy.

Hearing this, Akbar Khan decided to set a trap to expose Macnaghten's duplicity. On the evening of 22 December, he sent out two of his cousins to the cantonment. They were escorted by Captain James Skinner, a young Anglo-Indian cavalry commander and the son of the founder of Skinner's Horse, who had been captured and arrested on the first day of the uprising as he tried to flee from the city in a woman's burkha.

Over dinner, the Barakzai envoys made Macnaghten a startling new offer. The British could stay in Afghanistan until the spring, they said, and Shuja remain as shah, if the British supported Akbar Khan's bid to be wazir and to gain hold of the real reins of power. If Macnaghten would make a written undertaking to help him, make a colossal down-payment of £300,000 and an annuity of £40,000, then Akbar Khan would be happy to bring him the head of Aminullah Khan Logari. Macnaghten was apparently being offered a chance to tear up the recently agreed treaty and cut a secret deal with Akbar Khan. Given the extreme weakness of the British position, the terms were suspiciously generous, but, conceited to the last, Macnaghten seems to have convinced himself that his recent intrigues were so brilliant that Akbar had been forced to compromise in order to safeguard his position. Aminullah's head Macnaghten rejected, saying the arrest of Aminullah Khan and handing him over as a prisoner to the British would be enough;